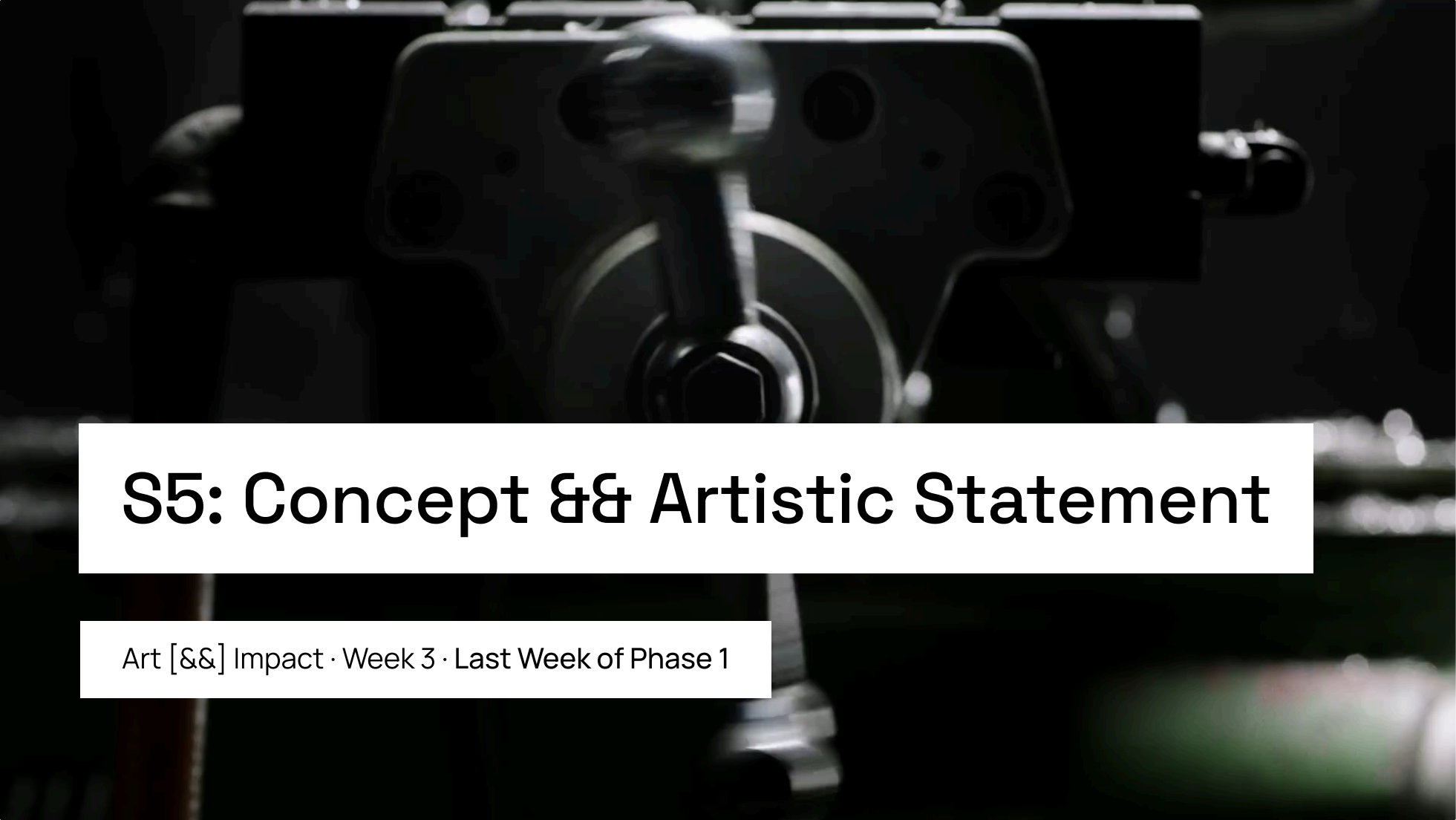


S5: Concept && Artistic Statement

Art [&&] Impact · Week 3 · Last Week of Phase 1

Where We Are

← WEEKS 1–2

Concept Development and Field Knowledge

Inward lens · Position sentence · Outward lens · Art Context · Four Questions for Impact

TODAY

Artistic Statement

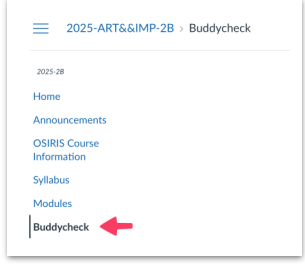
Concept → Statement · Three components · Developing your Statement

→ TOMORROW

S6 — Statement Presentations

Concept commitment · Internal audience · Phase 1 deliverables

Buddycheck now open! Fill in to evaluate team work and individual contributions (part of personal grade component)



Defining Your Concept and Artistic Statement

Concept Draft vs. Artistic Statement

- The concept draft describes **what** your installation does and **how you go about it**.
- The artistic statement is a description of the **intention and meaning** of your work. A strong statement does three things:

IT STATES A POSITION

Not a description of what you built — an account of **what the work means** and what it is trying to say.

IT IS PERSONAL

Only possible from your team's **specific angle** — the experience, obsession, or perspective that brought you to this concept rather than any other.

AUDIENCE FOCUSED

What **happens to the person** who encounters the work. Not what you hope they feel — what the work is **designed to elicit**.

S2 introduced the statement as a seed. S3 introduced diagnostic tools for your concept. Today you prepare your statement and concept for presentation.

Interpreting Artistic Statements

Taking a Position · Personal · Audience Focused

“Cut Piece”

Yoko Ono · 1964

Ono knelt on stage. The audience was invited to come forward and cut away pieces of her clothing with scissors — one cut each. She did not react. She did not stop them.

- **Position:** When a woman offers her body as material and the audience is handed scissors, every choice — to cut, to hesitate, to watch — is a moral act.
- **Personal:** Ono — as a Japanese woman artist subject to the Western male gaze — put her own body on the line this way. The vulnerability is personal.
- **Audience:** People who came to observe art and find themselves making a choice about another person’s body — designed to make everyone in the room implicated, including those who didn’t move.

“Speculative Rituals of Debt”

Nabila Ernada · 2024

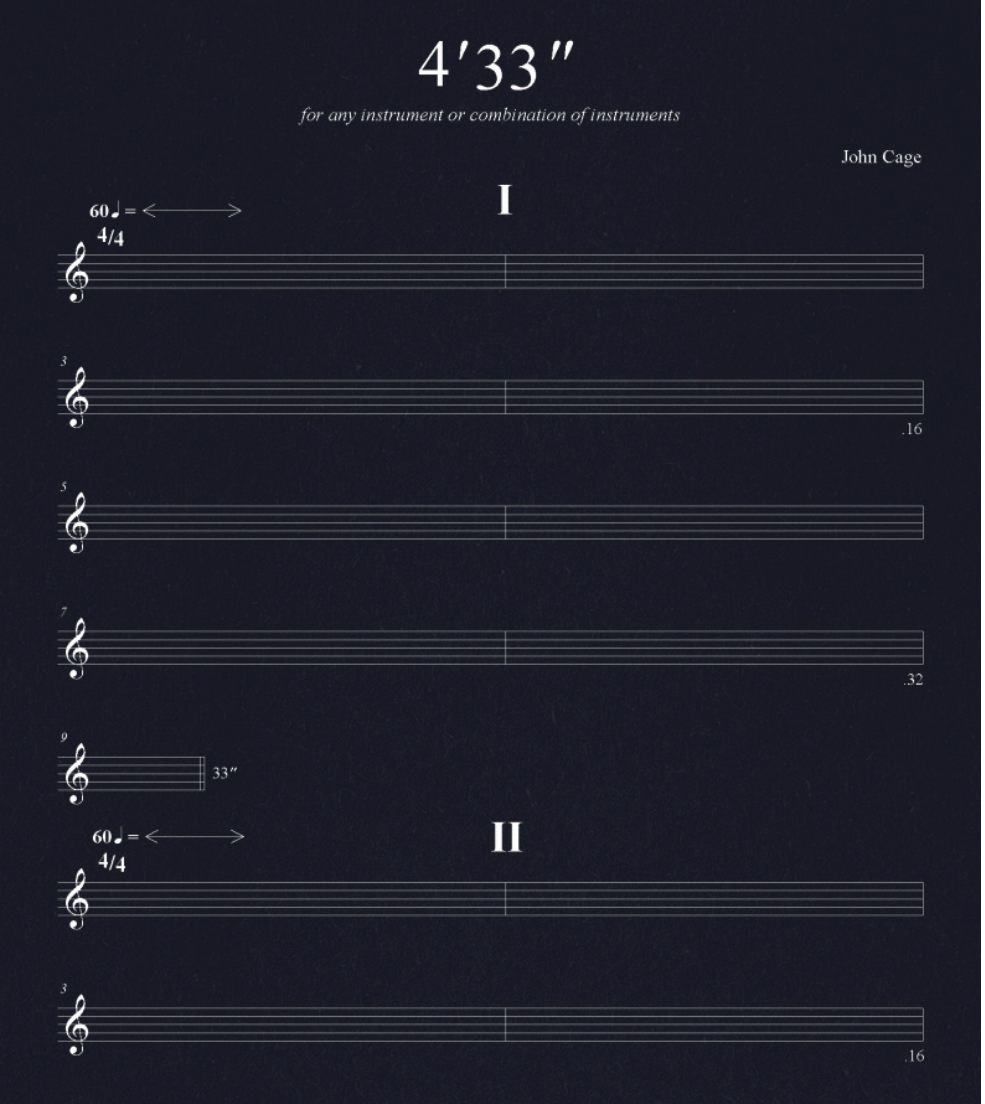
- **Position:** Susuk binds you to a spirit; a loan binds you to a bank — both extract something personal in exchange for power you didn’t have before.
- **Personal:** Ernada has a personal fascination of Southeast Asian spiritual practice and her experience of global financial systems.
- **Audience:** Designed to make monetary relationships feel uncanny and more personal; what seemed contractual begins to feel like possession.

“I Can’t Help Myself”

Sun Yuan & Peng Yu · 2016

You analyzed this in S2. Apply the three parts of the framework: position, personal, and audience.

- **Position:** Control performed without end and without result is not strength — it is the most honest portrait of what power actually looks like.
- **Personal:** Sun Yuan & Peng Yu’s practice is built on watching systems labor past the point of sense — this is work that comes from a sustained obsession with futility.
- **Audience:** Designed to elicit both sympathy and dread through movements and use of evocative fluids.



“4’33””

John Cage · 1952

You experienced this in S3. Apply the three parts of the framework: position, personal, and audience.

- **Position:** There is no silence — only sounds we have agreed not to call music yet. Cage’s work refuses that agreement.
- **Personal:** Cage arrived here through Zen practice and a commitment to indeterminacy — someone who had learned to let go of authorship entirely.
- **Audience:** Designed to make every ambient sound feel significant, and for that significance not to disappear when they leave the hall.

Taking a Risk

Commit to Taking a Risk

An artistic statement commits to something!

✕ DESCRIPTION (NO RISK)

"We are exploring the relationship between technology and identity."

Everyone agrees. Nothing is at stake. **This is a topic, not a position.**

✓ STATEMENT (WITH RISK)

"Digital interfaces train us to become biological machines — and we consent to it every time we tap 'agree'."

Someone could push back: "Consent is still consent." That tension is what makes for an interesting position.

2 min – Solo Read your current concept draft.

Find a sentence of your premise that someone could push back on.

That sentence is probably your position at work!

02:00

Start Edit

The Three Components

A strong artistic statement does three things:

1 · IT STATES A POSITION

Not a description of what you built — an account of **what the work means** and what it is trying to say.

One or two sentences you could defend if someone pushes back.

2 · IT IS PERSONAL

Only possible from your team's **specific angle** — the particular experience, obsession, or perspective that brought you to this concept rather than any other.

Working Session

🟡 Brain-first

🕒 50min

PRESENTATION FORMAT *(1-2 SPEAKERS)*

5 min presentation + 5 min critique

- Your **artistic statement**
- **Concept** and **interaction sketch**: what does a visitor do?
- Declared **technology track** + rationale
- Use any presentation style that helps convey your statement

PORTFOLIO SECTIONS *(TEAM)*

1. **Artistic Statement:** ~200–400 words. Position, not a description. Written for a public reader.
2. **Concept** — What the audience experiences in your installation plus a rough spatial sketch and your blocking question (answered in trials).
3. **Technology Track** — Track name, technique rationale (a paragraph), one reference work with a note on what you take from it.

AAAI-W3 Phase 1 Group Deliverables

Start Assignment

Due Friday by 11:59pm **Points** 10 **Submitting** a file upload **File Types** zip

Submit your team's Notion portfolio (via the export feature). It must include your artistic statement and technology track rationale. Make sure everything is archived into a single ZIP file for submission.

Use the following export options:

- **Export format:** Markdown & CSV
- **Include content:** Everything
- **Include subpages** (ON) and **create folders for subpages** (ON)

What your portfolio must contain

Your portfolio is built from the work you have already done in Week 1 and Week 2. By the time you submit, you are not starting from scratch; you are polishing and completing what you have.

Section	Content	Submission Details
Artistic Statement	The statement is written for someone who knows nothing about your process — a visitor to the exhibition, a reader of the portfolio, someone who encounters your work without any context. Write for that person. A strong artistic statement does three things: **It states a position.** The statement is not a description of what you built but an account of what the work means and what it is trying to say. **It is personal.** Your statement should only be possible from your team's specific angle. It draws on the inward lens — the particular experience, obsession, or perspective that brought you to this concept rather than any other. **It accounts for the audience.** A statement about interactive art has to include what happens to the person who encounters the work. Not what you hope they feel but what the work is designed to elicit.	• 200–400 words. • Written in plain, accessible language. Not academic, not promotional. • In the first person plural (we) or the third person. • Not addressed to the course instructors. Write as if it will be published alongside the work.
Concept	Your concept section builds directly on your Week 1 concept draft. By the Phase 1 submission, it should reflect some refinements you made along the way. Add the following to your existing concept draft: **Rough spatial sketch:** A drawing of what someone physically encounters: where things are, how the space is structured, where the audience moves or stands. Does not need to be to scale or technically resolved. Include it in the portfolio as an image — photograph or scan is fine. **Blocking question:** The single question that, if unanswerable, would break the concept.	• Working title • One-sentence premise • Audience scenario • Theme relationship • Rough spatial sketch • Blocking question
Technology Track	Your technology track section is the content you submitted in Week 2, now finalised and placed in the portfolio. If your track has changed since Week 2, note the change and explain the reason. 1. **Track name** — Code & Visuals / Real-Time 3D / Projection & AV / Physical + Digital 2. **Technique rationale** — one paragraph explaining why this track suits your concept. 3. **Reference work** — one existing artwork or project that uses a similar technical approach, with a brief note on what it does and what you take from it.	• Track name • Technique rationale • Reference work

You are also encouraged to draw from the your individual AI & Me material to discuss how the group uses (or opposes) the involvement of GenAI for their work!

AAAI-W3 Phase 1 Individual Deliverables

Start Assignment

Due Friday by 11:59pm **Points** 0 **Submitting** a text entry box or a file upload

The following are submitted individually via Canvas, separate from the Notion portfolio:

- **AI & Me** — document and submit at least two GenAI interactions or deliberate non-interactions from your Phase 1 work (Weeks 1–3). See the AI & Me examples for reference. Due at the same time as the portfolio.
- **Buddycheck 1** — peer evaluation form for each team member. Submitted individually via the Buddycheck link on Canvas.

Art [&&] Impact

See you tomorrow!